The Right to Be Heard

Civic Skill: Voice & Participation | EYLF: EYLF Outcome 1 (Identity) & Outcome 5 (Communicating) | Duration: 20–30 minutes | Age: 4–6 years

LEARNING INTENTION

Children will begin to understand that they have a right to share their ideas about things that affect them, and that adults have a responsibility to listen (UNCRC Article 12, introduced in child-friendly language).

SUCCESS CRITERIA

- I can say 'I have a right to be heard.'
- I can name one thing I would like to have a say about.
- I can describe what 'being heard' feels like in my body.

MATERIALS

- A large blank tree drawn or painted on butcher's paper ('Our Rights Tree')
- Leaf-shaped cut-outs, one or more per child
- Picture book: 'We Are All Born Free' (Amnesty International) or a similar child-friendly rights book
- A soft toy or puppet to act as the 'talking bird' who carries messages

ACTIVITY STEPS

1. OPENING CIRCLE (5 min): Introduce the puppet. 'This is our talking bird. The talking bird wants to know — does anyone ever get to decide things? What kinds of things?' Take a few quick answers.

2. BOOK READ-ALOUD (7 min): Read from 'We Are All Born Free.' Pause on the page about having a say. Ask: 'Did you know children have this too? What do you think that means for us, here, today?'

3. RIGHTS TREE (8 min): Each child draws or dictates onto a leaf 'something I would like to have a say about' — this can be small (what's for snack) or bigger (what we do outside). Educator scribes exact words where needed.

4. PLANTING THE LEAVES (5 min): One at a time, children bring their leaf to the tree, holding the talking bird as they place it and say their idea aloud if they wish. No explanation is required if a child prefers not to speak.

5. CLOSING CIRCLE (3 min): Introduce the phrase: 'If it's about us, ask us.' Practise saying it together. 'Our tree is full of things that matter to you. We're going to come back to it.'

EXTENSIONS

- Add new leaves to the Rights Tree throughout the term as new ideas come up
- Introduce a simple version of Article 12 in the daily routine — 'this is something that affects you, so we're asking you'
- Invite children to notice moments during the week when someone did or didn't ask them their view

ASSESSMENT

- Anecdotal note: does the child spontaneously reference their right to have a say in later discussions?
- Observe whether the child chooses to speak, or prefers the leaf alone to carry their message — both are valid forms of voice
- Photograph the growing tree as a portfolio artefact of the group's emerging rights vocabulary

EDUCATOR REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- Which children readily named something they wanted a say about, and which needed more scaffolding?
- Did any leaf surprise you — reveal something the child cares about that you hadn't noticed before?
- How consistently does your everyday practice already reflect 'if it's about us, ask us'? Where could it more?

EYLF LINKS

This lesson directly supports EYLF Outcome 1 (Identity) & Outcome 5 (Communicating). Educators should record observations using anecdotal notes, photographs, or learning stories focused on children's language, body responses, and social interactions during the session.